



Robotics Moving Closer To Asimov's Dreams

With technologies improving the sensory and perceptual power and hence the autonomy of robots in uncontrolled environments, there is increasing hope that the dreams of evangelists might one day come true. Not just robotic astronauts in space but even service robots in domestic and commercial spaces might become widespread by 2025

■ JANANI GOPALAKRISHNAN VIKRAM

As you walk into the Dalu Robot restaurant in the Jinan town of the Shandong Province in China, you are welcomed by a female robot into the 100-seater restaurant that is served completely by a dozen robots. The waiters do not grumble

or ask for tips, and as a newspaper reporter quipped, they do not spit in your food. That is because they do not feel tired however long a day stretches, nor do they understand emotions like exasperation or anger. In short, they are more patient.

However, at present, these robots do not come and serve you at your table. They just keep cycling around with

plates of food on their tray and stop when they notice any obstruction. So you have to simply put out your hand and grab your food when the cycling robot comes near you. The customers seem happy, but the owner hopes to upgrade to more capable robots that can go to every table, take orders and serve the customers in the traditional way.

T. Jayakrishnan, director and coun-